

Elsewhere, Within.: Explorations of Consciousness, Identity, and Play

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Abstract

Elsewhere, Within. began with a personal observation: while puzzles, riddles, and structured challenges can create focus, they do not inherently foster introspection. They engage cognition, but often fail to center the individual in a meaningful way. This project responds to that gap by developing a series of contemplative, interactive exercises designed to promote self-awareness and reflection.

Materialized as an artist-designed activity book, Elsewhere, Within. offers a quiet, self-directed space for inquiry—one that prioritizes uninterrupted thought and personal interpretation over prescriptive outcomes. While an immersive environment was initially considered, the final project emphasizes the book itself as the primary site of engagement, where tactile interaction and minimal design support sustained attention.

Grounded in research spanning mindfulness, cognitive science, and interactive design, this project reframes self-exploration as an experiential process. Rather than guiding participants toward fixed conclusions, it invites them to engage with uncertainty, observe their own patterns of thought, and construct meaning on their own terms.

Research Problem + Rationale

Traditional tools for self-reflection often operate within rigid psychological or spiritual frameworks, offering structured systems that leave little room for individualized meaning-making. At the same time, more casual or recreational cognitive activities—such as puzzles and games—engage attention without necessarily encouraging deeper introspection.

This reveals a gap between cognitive engagement and personal reflection: few models successfully integrate structured activity with open-ended self-inquiry.

Elsewhere, Within. addresses this gap by combining the two. It proposes that structured yet minimal prompts can create the conditions for introspection without prescribing outcomes. In doing so, the project shifts the role of the participant from passive recipient to active interpreter.

Situated within a broader cultural context of overstimulation and prescriptive self-help industries, the work offers an alternative approach—one that values slowness, presence, and personal agency over optimization and instruction.

Purpose Statement + Research Questions

The purpose of this project is to investigate how interactive, contemplative exercises can facilitate self-inquiry and deepen personal understanding of identity.

Rather than treating reflection as a purely internal or abstract process, this work explores how designed interactions—particularly those that are tactile, minimal, and open-ended—can shape the way individuals engage with their own thoughts.

Central Research Question:

How can interactive, contemplative exercises facilitate self-inquiry and deepen

Personal understanding of identity?

Sub-Questions:

How do structured activities influence attention, awareness, and introspection?

What role does openness (or ambiguity) play in enabling meaningful self-reflection?

How can design create conditions for inquiry without directing interpretation?

Research Overview + Literature Context

This project is informed by three primary areas of research: interactive design and cognition, mindfulness and identity, and immersive/participatory art practices.

In *Make It Stick* (Brown et al.) and *The Design of Everyday Things* (Norman), structured interaction is shown to shape how individuals process and retain information. These frameworks inform the construction of exercises that are simple yet cognitively engaging.

Csikszentmihalyi's concept of flow further emphasizes the importance of balancing structure and openness in order to sustain attention and immersion. This balance becomes central to the design of the book's prompts, which aim to guide without constraining.

Research in mindfulness (Kabat-Zinn; Goleman; Gallagher) underscores the value of sustained attention and present awareness in developing self-understanding. These ideas directly inform the project's emphasis on slowness, focus, and non-judgmental observation.

Finally, work in installation and interactive art (Bishop; Manovich; Grau) demonstrates how environments and participatory systems can reshape perception and engagement. While *Elsewhere, Within.* ultimately exists as an analog object, these influences inform its experiential design—particularly its emphasis on immersion, agency, and non-linear interaction.

Together, these fields support a central premise: that designed experiences can actively shape the conditions under which self-reflection occurs.

Project Description

Elsewhere, Within. takes the form of a printed activity book composed of structured yet open-ended exercises. Organized into four sections—Sketch, Write, Play, and Define—the book offers multiple entry points into self-inquiry, allowing participants to move fluidly between different modes of engagement.

The exercises are intentionally minimal and non-linear. Participants are not expected to complete the book sequentially; instead, they are encouraged to enter at any point and revisit pages over time. This structure reinforces the idea that reflection is not a linear process, but an evolving one.

Prompts range from written and visual exercises to abstract and interpretive tasks. Many resist clear resolution, instead encouraging participants to sit with ambiguity, question assumptions, and observe their own responses.

The analog format is central to the project's methodology. By removing digital distractions, the book creates a focused environment that supports sustained attention and deeper engagement.

Methods of Data Collection + Iteration

The development of *Elsewhere, Within.* involved iterative prototyping and informal user testing. Participants were invited to engage with early versions of the book and reflect

on their experiences, providing qualitative insight into how different prompts shaped attention, interpretation, and emotional response.

These reflections were analyzed thematically, identifying patterns in how users engaged with structure, ambiguity, and pacing. This process informed revisions to the book's design, ensuring that the final set of exercises maintained a balance between guidance and openness.

Rather than presenting findings as external data visualizations, the results of this process are embedded within the design of the book itself—reflected in its tone, sequencing, and conceptual clarity.

Implications

Elsewhere, *Within.* positions interactive design not as a tool for delivering answers, but as a framework for sustained attention and self-inquiry. By balancing structure with openness, the project demonstrates how minimal interventions can meaningfully shape the conditions under which reflection occurs.

Rather than guiding participants toward fixed interpretations, the work creates space for ambiguity, allowing meaning to emerge through engagement over time. In this way, the project reframes introspection as an active, ongoing process—one that is constructed